EMBA 746 (Class 60)
Global Supply Chain Management
Fall 2025

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COURSE DESCRIPTION & OBJECTIVES

The trend towards an integrated world economy and global competitive arena is forcing companies to develop strategies for designing products and services for global markets while optimizing the firm's choice of sourcing and production locations in supplying them. Planning and operating in the global arena require new general management skills – for example, developing a truly global network of suppliers, distribution centers, and consolidation points; optimizing multiple transport service types; coordination of vast outsourcing and logistics networks for a multiplicity of production and service activities; and designing information and communication systems that integrate the supply chain. Furthermore, recent events have reminded us of the importance of managing risks in global sourcing, production, and distribution networks. We need to build agile and resilient global supply chains.

This course is a three-credit course that we conceptually divide into three main parts:

(1) Global Operational Network Design ("Agility")
(2) Integrated Operational Risk Management ("Resilience")
(3) CSR and Global Operations: Corporate Social Responsibility, Technology & Future of Supply Chains ("Responsible Future")

In ***"Global Operational Network Design,"*** we deal with the global footprint design of where to locate plants and distribution centers, and which products and markets to serve from which parts and distribution centers. Trade uncertainty and tariffs, pandemic logistic challenges, Brexit, and political uncertainties have resurfaced issues of outsourcing and reshoring, regionalization, and substantial restructuring of global operations. We identify tradeoffs in operational network design and discuss ways to operationally hedge uncertainty and risk through building operational flexibility and ***agility*** in global operations.

In ***"Integrated Operational Risk Management,"*** we expose participants to the many risks in global supply chains and offer a well-formulated risk management framework to deal with them. Today's leaner, just-in-time, globalized supply chains are more vulnerable than ever to operational risks, and to natural and man-made disasters. This requires you to learn how to build the right flexibility within the supply chain and integrate disruption management thinking into every facet of your logistics and supply chain operations. Our ***Integrated Risk Management (IRM) framework*** illustrates the benefits of combining operational and financial hedging in dealing with such risks and offers a portfolio of proven strategies for managing logistics, operational and supply chain risks for ***robust*** and ***resilient*** operations**.**

In ***"Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Global Operations,"*** we take a business-oriented perspective to explore the tradeoffs and synergies that exist between firms' ecological and other social responsibilities and financial performance. Using a broad ***Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) factors framework***, we discuss how environmental and other social (employee treatment, human rights, product liability, etc.) issues affect global operations and their risks. Our discussion emphasizes the supply chain requirements behind ***circular economy*** business models and the variation of strategies in achieving it. Finally, we look at the impact of ***new technologies*** (especially ***Artificial Intelligence (AI)*** / Machine Learning) ***on supply chains*** and the resulting operational transformation and its implementation challenges (***Responsible Future***).

The course builds heavily on and constructively supports the **"global orientation"** and **"values-based, data-driven"** pillars of our business school curriculum, with elements of an ***"experiential"*** approach in teaching the material.

HOW TO ACHIEVE THE COURSE OBJECTIVES

The course is not oriented towards prospective specialists in supply chain management. Its first goal is to introduce you to the environment and help you appreciate the problems that global supply chain managers confront. I shall attempt to accomplish this goal by sending you on (conceptually) guided tours or asking you to analyze representative cases of global supply chain systems. We shall then, typically, discuss some system specifics while emphasizing principles and issues that are both common to these systems and play key roles in their management.

The second goal is to teach you some methods and techniques that have been (or hopefully will be) found useful for designing, running, controlling, and improving global supply chain systems. The only way to accomplish this goal is to carry out the assignments (reading, discussing, simulations, games, number crunching) that we will give you throughout the course.

The third and most important goal is to enable you to combine the facts, problems, and techniques covered in the course into a coherent and useful framework on how to address challenging global supply chain decisions, which will motivate you to further explore some of the many directions in which you start acquiring knowledge. Naturally, working hard on the first two goals is a prerequisite for achieving the third.

I shall not make explicit attempts to convince you of how crucial the global supply chain operations and sourcing function are to the success of an organization. I hope that you begin the course equipped with such a conviction, simply being informed by realities in the marketplace. I also hope that the course material will help you crystallize such conviction within yourself, as well as inspire you to delegate it to others.

TEAMWORK

I strongly encourage you to work in teams (always within the allowable limits of the Honor Code of the Olin Business School, and the more specific Course Ethics Code, see below). It is a unique opportunity to learn how to work effectively in teams and to use advantageously the talents of the other members of your team. However, you should plan very carefully the individual effort that you must allocate before and after team meetings (that effort varies greatly among individuals). For the team assignments, you must submit only one copy of the report. All team members receive the same grade on team assignments.

COURSE ETHICS CODE

I propose the following ethics code for this course. It aims **"to promote an environment of mutual respect, trust and academic integrity of the highest order." We expect students to "conduct themselves in an ethical manner and adhere to the highest standards of truth and honesty."** By accepting this code, we will enjoy the benefits that it engenders. As your instructor, I trust that you will not cheat or violate the instructions and, as a student, you enjoy the freedom of a flexible environment that suits your needs. The ethics code applies to all activities in the "Global Supply Chain Management" course.

Case analysis and discussion: Successful case analysis requires fresh perspectives, and no prior knowledge of how the case was "solved" by the company or "analyzed" by other students or experts. It is fine (in fact, it is a good idea) to discuss case content with other students in the same course prior to coming to class. However, you should not seek inside information on cases (e.g., through the library). You should not discuss cases with students who might have taken the course in the past. Likewise, you should not reveal the outcomes of the case or case discussion with students who will encounter the case in the future. We present below additional limitations on case discussion, in the sections on Individual Assignments and Team Assignments.

Individual assignments: You may not copy the assignment or portions of the assignment of other students, and you may not collaborate with others in writing the individual assignment. You should not discuss the individual assignments with others prior to their due date. Use of chatbots or various large language models (like ChatGPT) should be appropriately referenced for their use and extent of use where it applies. Their use may reflect in the grading of the assignment.

Team assignments: The group reports are to be completed by your team, without the aid of other teams. You should not discuss the assignment with members of other teams in the course or with students who have completed the assignment in the past. Use of chatbots or various large language models (like ChatGPT) should be appropriately referenced for their use and extent of use where it applies. Their use may reflect in the grading of the assignment.

Case notes: You should not make use of any case write-ups prepared by current or previous students or case notes prepared by students or instructors here or at other universities. Use of such notes corrupts the learning process. Use of chatbots or various large language models (like ChatGPT) should be appropriately referenced where it applies. Their use may reflect in the grading of the assignment.

COURSE MATERIAL

We will provide all the material you need (i.e., readings, case studies) for the course in the distributed **Course Packet (CP).**

COURSE GRADE

Individual Assignments:

Take Home Final (individual, **optional**, required for HP**)**	10%
Take Home Learning Journal #1 (required)	20%
Take Home Learning Journal #2 (required)	20%

Team Assignments:

Global Supply Chain Management Simulation/Write-Up	15%
Circular Economy Simulation/Write-Up	15%
Case Presentations	20%

Our course takes place over two weekends consisting of six 4½ hour sessions. The **first weekend** is ***November 13-15*** (the course takes place in the morning of these three days), and the **second weekend** is ***December 11-13*** (the course takes place in the morning of these three days). **After each weekend**, each student has an individual assignment to complete, a ***"learning journal"*** for that weekend. These assignments are of a reflective nature to the learned material. We ask you to apply to an industry, company, or timely issue of your interest the learning concepts, and effectively express your course learning in your own words. The learning journal requires you to write a **short report of around three pages**. These "learning journals" are due **one week after** the completion of **the corresponding weekend.** We will distribute formal assignments for each learning journal at the end of the corresponding teaching weekend.

There is an **Optional Take Home Case Study,** which we will distribute on the last day of our course. You do not need to complete it in order to qualify for a passing grade in the course. However, it is **required for all those who wish to qualify for a high pass grade**. It is due **December 29, 2025.**

In each class session, we will ask some teams to help with the case discussion and presentation. We will ask teams assigned to a case to present brief answers to some of the case discussion questions. The team will send their PowerPoint or notes to the instructor and the TA, either prior to or immediately after the case discussion session. We will post the discussion question(s) assigned to each team on the **Canvas site** prior to the class session we will discuss the case. This assignment appears with the **"Case Presentations"** label in the grading formula.

Finally, an important aspect of the course relates to its **experiential activities (simulations).** For our first weekend, the **"Global Supply Chain Management Simulation"** is our experiential exercise held in the ***late morning of November 14, 2025***. For our second weekend, the **"Circular Economy Simulation: Fashion Forward"** is our newly introduced experiential exercise held in the ***late morning of December 12, 2025.*** We provide more details for both of these simulations later in the syllabus.

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SESSION 1: November 13, 2025 (Morning, 8:00 am - 12:30 pm)

Main Topics: *Structure of Global Supply Chains & Current Challenges*

Required Readings:

1. "Supply Chains Belong at the Top of a CEO's Agenda," ***HBR.org***, September 30, 2024 (CP)
2. "8 Questions to Ask About Your Globalization Strategy Right Now," ***HBR.org***, November 19, 2024 (CP)
3. "The Apple Squeeze," Chapter 30 (pages 267-277) from the book ***Apple in China*** by Patrick McGee, 2025 (CP)
4. "Plan B-Assembled in India," Chapter 40 (pages 362-371) from the book ***Apple in China*** by Patrick McGee, 2025 (CP)
5. "Apple Silicon," Chapter 38 (pages 221-224) from the book ***Chip War*** by Chris Miller, 2022 (CP)

Case Study (1): ***Apple Inc.: Global Supply Chain Management (CP)***
Case Study (2): ***Apple's Supply Chain Transformation (CP)***

Case Study (1) is set in early 2020, it provides a detailed description of the company's supply chain network and capabilities. Data in this case will allow us to develop an understanding of Apple's source of competitiveness and to gain insights into the management of a large, complex, global supply chain network that focuses on the intersection of services, hardware, and software.

As part of our discussion, we will be able to:

- Assess Apple's supply chain and identify its key competitive advantages.
- Quantify Apple's ability to generate value from its supply chain.
- Identify potential opportunities and challenges for Apple in improving its supply chain.
- Discuss the recent challenges of the US-China tariff trade war, and for Apple to consider adjusting its China-centered global supply chain.

Discussion Questions:

1. How does the iPhone relate to Apple's strategy to expand its services and wearable offerings? Are the product and service segments intertwined? How profitable is the iPhone? How have the margins changed since 2007?
2. Describe important aspects of the iPhone supply chain (from product development, procurement, outsourcing, logistics, distribution, retail network, sustainability, etc.). Do Apple's supply chain capabilities represent a source of competitive advantage? Why or why not? Support your analysis using data from the case.
3. What are the main business challenges Apple is currently facing, and what are the implications for its supply chain strategy? How does the supply chain for the iPhone need to change as the smartphone market matures? What is the impact of the "Cook Doctrine" (mentioned in page 6 of the case) on the structure of the supply chain? How will Apple's increased emphasis on its services affect the supply chain?
4. How big is the problem resulting from the US-China tariff and trade war for Apple? How can Apple respond to higher tariffs for imports from China?
5. What are the risks of a supply chain relocation out of China for Apple? Which options does Apple have in adjusting its China-centered global supply chain?

Case Study (2) deals with more recent developments, and it comes to a close in February 2023, with Apple announcing it had not met Wall Street revenue, profit, and sales expectations. The case presents several key new challenges that Apple needs to resolve. It will give us an opportunity to further build on our previous case discussion (especially questions 4 and 5), while at the same time looking at some new questions:

6. What are the most significant supply chain challenges Apple is currently facing?
7. Where and why should Apple deploy vertical integration?
8. If you were Tim Cook in early 2024, what strategic recommendations would you make? What are the best ways to increase its supply chain resilience and adaptability to respond better to market volatility?

SESSION 2: November 14, 2025 (Morning, 8:00 am - 12:30 pm)

Main Topic: *Structure of Global Supply Chains (Continued): Reshoring & Global Supply Chain Risks/ Impact of Tariffs on Supply Chains*

Required Readings:

1. "Bringing Manufacturing Back to the U.S. is Easier Said than Done," ***HBR.org,*** April 15, 2020 (CP)
2. "What Barbie tells you about near-shoring," ***Economist,*** 2023 (CP)
3. "The Tariff Wars Just Upended Your Supply Chain. Here's How to Adapt," ***HBR.org,*** April 9, 2025 (CP)
4. "Tariffs, Technology, and the New Geography of Manufacturing," ***HBR.org,*** June 2, 2025 (CP)
5. Chapter 8, "Risk" from the ***Supply Chain Science*** book, by Wally Hopp (CP)

Case Study: ***Tariff Shock: Sustainable Sneaker Start-Up OKEPAS Battles a Broken Supply Chain (CP)***

This case is about the challenges faced by a sustainable sneaker startup as it confronts a sudden and dramatic increase in US tariffs on Chinese manufactured goods in April 2025. The case highlights the complexities of global supply chains, the risks of political and economic shocks, and the strategic decisions required to build resilient global supply chains. Okepas, founded by industry veterans, built its business model around mass customization, sustainability, and a lean, China based supply chain. When tariffs on footwear imports soared to 145%, Okepas' cost structure became unsustainable, threatening its survival in its largest market.

Discussion Questions:

1. Given the tariff escalation in April 2025, what short- and long-term risks does Okepas face in continuing to rely on a China-centered supply chain?
2. Could partial relocation of production (e.g., manufacturing the white base shoes in China and competing customization in Italy or the US for the European and US markets, respectively) offer a viable form of operational postponement? What are the trade-offs in terms of lead time, cost and control?

3. To what extent should Okepas revisit its pricing strategy given its high cost of goods sold (COGS) and minimal margins?
4. What strategic options should Stefano Ferniani, CEO at Okepas consider mitigating tariff exposure while maintaining Okepas' made-to-order, premium customization model?
5. What capabilities and supply chain structures would be required for Okepas to build a resilient, future proof operating model?

Global Supply Chain Management Simulation (Experiential Exercise)

You will play the **"Global Supply Chain Management Simulation,"** which you will access via the web. You should expect to devote 90 minutes during the late morning of **November 14, 2025,** to playing the game in teams. We will debrief the simulation in class after our game playing (debriefing in next morning session). As an assignment you will work on a **team write-up** of related questions to the simulation (**due** one week later on **November 21, 2025, by 5:00 pm,** and you can expect to devote one hour or so as a team working on it).

SESSION 3: November 15, 2025 (Morning, 8:00 am - 12:30 pm)

Main Topics: *Building Supply Chain Resilience/ Pandemic Crisis and Global Supply Chains/ Post-pandemic Risks in Global Supply Chains*

Required Readings:

1. "Global Supply Chains in a Post-Pandemic World," ***HBR,*** 2020 (CP)
2. "Paradoxes and Mysteries in Virus-Infected Supply Chains: Hidden bottlenecks, changing consumer behaviors, and other non-usual suspects," by Kouvelis, ***Business Horizons,*** 2022 (CP)
3. "What Really Makes Toyota's Production System Resilient" by Willy Shih, ***HBR.org,*** 2022 (CP)
4. "How Contracts Can Help Firms Navigate the Uncertainty of Global Tariffs," ***HBR.org,*** April 11, 2025 (CP)

Recent Research Readings (optional):

1. "Bespoke Supply Chain Resilience: The Gap between Theory and Practice," Kouvelis et al., ***Journal of Operations Management***, ***2022*** (CP)

Case Study: ***Toyota's Disrupted Global Supply Chain: COVID-19 and the Global Chip Shortage*** **(CP)**

The case provides a context for examining how companies can manage supply risks for black swan events such as the global microchip shortage that Toyota and other automakers faced during the coronavirus pandemic. The case provides some understanding of the unique challenges associated with global supply shortages, especially during black swan events. In addition, it offers insights into how leaders can identify and manage supply chain risks. We have an opportunity to build upon the principles of "lean" approach for core process efficiency and the added needs, and supporting concepts, in building "resilience" for future unexpected shocks.

Discussion Questions:

1. What are some of the unique attributes of the Toyota Production System, and what are the implications for Toyota's supply chain? In what ways might these aspects of Toyota's system and supply chain make it vulnerable

to unexpected ("black swan") events like the 2011 earthquake in Japan and, more recently, the global COVID pandemic? What is the extent of the application of "Lean" (Toyota Production System (TPS)) principles in the metal industry (either at mills or at service centers)?

2. What did Toyota learn from the 2011 earthquake and tsunami? What changes did the company make to create a more resilient supply chain? If we state it in different words, what practices did they put in place after the 2011 disaster to create future resilience? Did they result in substantial deviation from the "lean practices"?
3. Did the changes that Toyota made after the earthquake in its supply chain help with the global chip shortages in 2020 and 2021? How would you compare Toyota's performance during the pandemic, and especially during the chip shortages, to the other automakers? Would you call the Toyota supply chain resilient in its performance during the 2020-2022 window? Doing a quick assessment of the metal services industry performance (both mills and service centers) how effectively have companies responded to the pandemic crisis? How do pre-pandemic (let us say 2018-19) inventory levels compare to post-pandemic (2022-23) levels?
4. What interesting practices did other automakers use to deal with the global chip shortage? How would you adopt these practices to prepare for future shocks in other causes and materials? What further lessons can Toyota learn from the chip shortage situation, and what actions could they take to improve resilience for future shocks?
5. Some argue that automakers share some of the blame for the chip shortages during the pandemic period. How did automakers contribute to the global chip shortage? What could they have done differently? In what ways did automakers mismanage the "bullwhip" effect in the early 2020? What might have been a better reaction on their part?

SESSION 4: December 11, 2025 (Morning, 8:00 am - 12:30 pm)

Main Topics: *Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) in Global Supply Chains/ Balancing Green: Sustainable & Profitable Supply Chains*

Required Readings:

1. "What's Your Strategy for Supply Chain Disclosure?" ***SMR,*** 2016 (CP)
2. "Consumer Pressure is Key to Fixing Dire Labor Conditions in the Clothing Supply Chain," ***HBR.org,*** 2022 (CP)
3. "How Ethical is Your Supply Chain?" **HBSP** (IIR272-PDF-ENG) (CP)
4. "Sustainability Chiefs are Recalibrating in Bid to Keep Decarbonization on Map," ***WSJ,*** June 25, 2025 (CP)
5. "A Carbon Tariff is the Right Way to Confront China on Trade," ***Washington Post,*** June 23, 2025 (CP)
6. "Carbon Footprints: Methods and Calculations," ***HBS 9-611-075***, 2024 (CP)

(Mini) Case Study (1): ***"When Tragedy Strikes the Supply Chain" HBR,*** 2016 (***HBR*** reprint Case Study + Commentary R1601K) (CP)

We will discuss the above mini case on strategic sourcing from emerging markets with the added complexities of business ethics, disruption risk management, supply chain strategy and the human cost of a $5 T-shirt.

Discussion Questions:

1. What are the consequences of the factory collapse in Bangladesh for T&T? How would you quantify such consequences? Especially, elaborate on reputational risks and their implications, and your approach in quantifying them. Feel free to search in the literature for how similar events (e.g., Rana Plaza building collapse in Dhaka, Bangladesh in 2013, etc.) have affected companies and their supply chains and parallels you might draw.
2. How should a retailer like T&T risk managing such events? How do you plan for them, what mitigation strategies would you put in place, how and what do you monitor, and what is the best organizational reaction to these occurrences?

3. Should T&T stay in Bangladesh? If yes, what actions should they take to ensure that future occurrences are less likely and less consequential for them? If not, where should they locate (China, Vietnam, Europe, U.S., Mexico, etc.) and why? How does this decision change their global supply chain risks?
4. Evaluate John Manners-Bell's recommendation and logic to support it. What are the strengths of the argument, and what are the counterpoints you would bring up if you had to oppose it? Evaluate Adam Kanzer's recommendation and logic to support it. What are the strengths of his argument, and what are the counterpoints you would bring up if you had to oppose it? When you fully account for both experts' recommendations, what is your recommendation for T&T on what to do next?

(Main) Case Study (2): ***Sustainability at IKEA Group (CP)***

Already the world's largest home furnishing company, IKEA Group, sought to double its sales within a decade mainly by expanding in emerging markets. The company recently hired a Chief Sustainability Officer and adopted a new sustainability strategy that focused the company's efforts on its entire value chain, including raw materials, its suppliers' production processes, its stores and factories, and consumer's use and disposal of products. The case focuses on IKEA Group's efforts to manage the environmental impacts associated with its use of wood, which constituted the majority of its total procurement volume. The company needs to design and deploy a sustainability plan to procure wood to support production processes and stores located throughout the world, especially in the context of the company's aggressive growth plans. This case helps us understand tradeoffs associated with alternative approaches to reducing the environmental impacts of a firm's global supply chain, including altering product design to avoid problematic supply chains, monitoring suppliers' adherence to environmental standards, and vertically integrating to own and operate upstream activities.

Discussion Questions:

1. Is IKEA's sustainability strategy well aligned with its business model? Is IKEA's sustainability strategy well oriented to address the company's most important environmental vulnerabilities and opportunities? Why or why not?

2. How would you grade IKEA Group's sustainability initiatives so far? Discuss different initiatives on a discrete scale: Not Impressive, Moderate, and Transformational. Please, explain your logic behind the ranking of the initiatives.
3. The case describes four options IKEA can pursue to manage environmental impacts of its wood supply chain (see below). For each option, describe pros/cons. Are there synergies or conflicts between these options? The options are:
    a. Increase forest ownership
    b. Increase targets/stringency of standards
    c. Shift its product designs from solid wood to particle board
    d. Shift from virgin wood to recycled wood
4. Which of these options do you consider transformational? If you could pursue just one of these, which one would you pursue. What are the challenges you anticipate in executing it?

SESSION 5: December 12, 2025 (Morning, 8:00 am – 12:30 pm)

Main Topics: *Design & Manage Circular Supply Chains*
Circular Economy Simulation (Experiential Simulation)

Required Readings:

1. "The Circular Business Model," ***HBR,*** 2021 (CP)
2. "Construction Firms Go Circular as They Try to Meet Demand for Greener Office Buildings," ***WSJ,*** 2024
3. "Fashion Brands Face New Skepticism on Green Claims," ***WSJ,*** 2024 (CP)
4. "How Smaller Companies Can Join the Circular Economy," ***HBR.org,*** June 27, 2024 (CP)

Case Study: ***IKEA: Becoming a Circular Business (CP)***

Global furniture retailer IKEA announced its intent to become a circular and climate-positive business by 2030. The case is a useful tool for discussing circular economies, reverse logistics, closed loop supply chains, sustainability, corporate social responsibility, end-of-life product management and product returns.

Discussion Questions:

1. What are the key pillars in IKEA's plan for achieving circularity in its business? What do you foresee, at a high level, as challenges in its implementation?
2. How important are "reverse logistics" flows in implementing the IKEA circular plan? What are challenges associated with the reverse logistics implementation at IKEA? How do you suggest IKEA addresses them?
3. What are the strengths and weaknesses of IKEA's sell-back program?
4. What is your opinion on the often-raised question if IKEA is truly focused on sustainability and responsibility or simply engaging in an easy to sell sustainable marketing program? What is your estimated probability of success of IKEA's circular business program?

Circular Economy Simulation: Fashion Forward (Experiential Simulation)

You will play the **"Circular Economy Simulation,"** which you will access via the web. You should expect to devote 60 minutes or so playing the simulation in teams during the late morning of **December 12, 2025.** We will debrief the simulation in class (debriefing in next morning session). As an assignment you will work on a short **PPT presentation** of related questions to the simulation (due one week later, **December 19, 2025, by 5 pm**, and you can expect to devote one hour or so as a team working on it after playing the simulation).

The clothing industry produces 100 billion items each year, of which only 1% are fully recycled and 73% end up in a landfill or are incinerated. No other industry illustrates the need and challenge of moving away from a take-and-make-use-dispose linear model towards a **circular economy** than the **fast fashion industry**. ***In this simulation, we manage the Design, Manufacturing and Retail activities of a fast fashion company for a period of five years***. By choosing initiatives across different parts of the company's value chain, we attempt to ***improve the company's circular performance and reduce waste while optimizing financial performance.***

SESSION 6: December 13, 2025 (Morning, 8:00 am - 12:30 pm)

Main Topics: *Emerging Technologies and the Digital Transformation of Supply Chains/ AI and Supply Chains/ Debriefing of Circular Economy Simulation/ Course Wrap-Up*

Required Readings:

1. "How Global Companies Use AI to Prevent Supply Chain Disruptions," ***HBR, 2023*** (CP)
2. "How Machine Learning Will Transform Supply Chain Management," ***HBR, 2024*** (CP)
3. "How Digital Integration is Reconfiguring Value Chains,***" HBR, 2025*** (CP)

Case Study: ***Tetra Pak: A Digitally Enabled Supply Chain as a Competitive Advantage (CP)***

The case describes the packaging supplier and equipment vendor Tetra Pak and its digital transformation program. It details why Tetra Pak undertook this effort, how it organized the program, how it identified and selected which technologies to implement, and the steps it took to overcome implementation challenges. The case is a general introduction to the definition of Industry 4.0 and the key technologies associated with the term.

Discussion Questions:

1. What are the businesses Tetra Pak is in? What is the company's value proposition and traditional strategy? What has been the role of innovation in Tetra Pak?
2. The case mentions the three pillars of Tetra Pak's approach to Industry 4.0: connected solutions, advanced analytics, and connected workforce. Without delving into the technical details of them, why do these initiatives make sense for Tetra Pak to pursue? What is the value proposition for Tetra Pak's customers? What other benefits are there for the company? What competitive advantages might they create? How can the company justify the investments needed?
3. What are the main challenges in the implementation of these initiatives? What ways would you recommend helping overcome organizational inertia, scale the initiatives, and overcome the resistance to change?